

The Boston Globe

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FRIDAY, FEBRUARY 28, 2025

‘It’s a perfect show of what cannabis does — it brings people together.’

RACHEL BACON, a cannabis yoga teacher who attended a class at Diaspora in Cambridge



BRETT PHELPS FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Samantha Francois smoked cannabis during a Bhang Yoga class at Diaspora. Participants join a private club.

STRETCHING THE CANNABIS BOUNDARIES

Still waiting for the state’s OK on public consumption spots, yoga classes and other businesses are finding creative ways to meet the demand

By Maren Halpin
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

On a recent Wednesday evening, in a second-floor studio overlooking Harvard Square, 15 people ended their day at a yoga class with a different kind of twist — cannabis.

After a warmup of downward dogs and deep breaths, yoga teacher Jacqueline Ortega gestured to a table displaying joints, complimentary with the \$30 class fee, and invited participants to spark up. The studio, adorned with white lanterns and floor-to-ceiling windows, filled with a skunky, hazy smoke as class members puffed away on brightly colored yoga mats.

“It’s a perfect show of what cannabis does — it brings people together,” said Rachel Bacon, another cannabis yoga teacher who attended the class at Diaspora, a private marijuana club.

Massachusetts could see a lot more of these marijuana-infused activities starting later this year, when the state plans to open applications for “social consumption” licenses, allowing lounges, cafes, and events to serve pot products in gathering spots.

Ortega’s class, called Bhang Yoga — bhang refers to a cannabis edible preparation dating back thousands of years in India — operates in something of a legal gray area. Participants’ class registration grants them

membership to a private cannabis club, Diaspora. A dispensary, the Boston Garden, cosponsored the class by providing the cannabis.

As instructors guided the class through yoga poses, breathing techniques, and deep stretches, some yogis paused for toke breaks, sending rings of smoke into the air. The class’s energy was lighthearted. As some lost their balance on trickier poses, many laughed through it together.

Businesses like Bhang Yoga have worked to find ways to offer experiences for Massachusetts residents to consume cannabis outside their homes, the only place consump-

YOGA, Page A5

Where guns run deep, a call for ban at bars

Vt. debates whether to be first state in N.E. to take the step

By Kevin Cullen
GLOBE STAFF

BURLINGTON, Vt. — Shortly after midnight on a summer night in August, a fight that started inside a popular bar in Burlington’s lively nightlife district spilled outside, where a 22-year-old woman allegedly pulled a .45-caliber pistol from her purse and shot to death a 30-

year-old man she said had harassed and hit her.

The shooting outside the Red Square bar sparked an outcry as a tragedy that should have been avoided. Even in a state where hunting and the right to bear arms are deeply revered traditions, it brought cries for new restrictions on guns. Now, a group of lawmakers, calling for common sense when it comes to guns and alcohol, have proposed a bill that would ban guns from bars and any establishment with a liquor license in Vermont.

The proposal, which could make

Vermont one of 16 states to ban guns in bars and the first in New England, has ignited a new debate about guns in a state that is both politically liberal and fiercely defensive about gun rights. The measure has found enthusiastic support from left-leaning politicians and pragmatists who say guns simply don’t belong where alcohol is served. But in a state where half of adults own guns, it has also set off intense pushback from gun rights advocates.

The recent legislation sprang

GUNS, Page A5

GENE HACKMAN 1930-2025 (OBITUARY, A10)

A versatile everyman, with a little something more

By Mark Feeney
GLOBE STAFF

Gene Hackman was a star without being a leading man. A leading man possesses some combination of handsomeness and personality and at least some acting ability. Hackman had the ability, all right, and in abundance. Handsomeness and personality? Not so much. His favorite actors as a boy were James Cagney and Errol Flynn. Hackman was descended from a different Studio Era star, Spencer Tracy.

Hackman was found dead Wednesday, along with his wife, Betsy Arakawa, and one of their dogs, in their New Mexico home. He was 95.

That lack of good looks or an outsize personality worked to Hackman’s advantage as an actor, helping make him the most versatile of a generation of great male stars. Jack Nicholson and Al Pacino and Dustin Hoffman were

his peers (as struggling actors in New York, he, Hoffman, and Robert Duvall were roommates at various times).

Unlike those three, Hackman onscreen evinced an absolute absence of ego. To say that he disappeared into a role isn’t quite right. His combination of vigor, control, and intelligence was hard not to notice. But what viewers noticed was the character Hackman was playing, not how Hackman was playing him.

You can see that in his best-known role, as the scabrous police detective Popeye Doyle, in “The French Connection” (1971). It won him a best actor Oscar. (It’s telling that three of Hackman’s five Oscar nominations were for supporting actor.) There’s nothing actorly about the performance, no winks to the audience to soften this violent, racist, ruthless guy and make him more appealing. Compelling, not appealing, was what interested Hackman.

HACKMAN, Page A10



FILM FORUM/PHOTOFEST

Gene Hackman won an Oscar for his performance as police detective Popeye Doyle in “The French Connection.”

Medicaid cuts could have huge impact here

Health care at stake for many and state economies would suffer, officials warn

More than 2 million people in

Massachusetts rely on what’s known as MassHealth, including 45 percent of all children in the state.

Massachusetts currently gets 50 cents from the federal government for every dollar it spends on most people in the program.

By Matt Stout and Jason Laughlin

GLOBE STAFF

Millions of Massachusetts residents could lose their health care, Governor Maura Healey warned this week. In Rhode Island, some health care facilities are bracing for a “death blow.”

And it’s not just people’s benefits that could suffer, officials warn, but local economies, too.

Such are the nightmare scenarios — and, some worry, real possibilities — if congressional Republicans trim, cut, or even gut federal spending on Medicaid, the country’s largest health insurance program and the single biggest piece of the budget in Massachusetts and elsewhere.

Funded jointly by the federal government and states, Medicaid provides health insurance for roughly one in five Americans, from impoverished children and low-income adults to seniors and those with disabilities reliant on care at home.

MEDICAID, Page A6

Despite Trump, Mass. educators urged to stay true to DEI

By John Hilliard and Christopher Huffaker

GLOBE STAFF

A high-stakes showdown over control of public school classrooms appeared certain between President Trump and Massachusetts, with Governor Maura Healey on Thursday directing educators to stay the course on diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives, while the federal administration encouraged unhappy parents and others to report schools for potential investigation.

Healey, Attorney General Andrea Joy Campbell, and state education officials issued legal guidances to Massachusetts schools that Trump’s directives do not override “existing law and well-established legal principles that encourage — and even require — schools to promote educational opportunity for students of all backgrounds.”

Healey said she issued the guidance to send a clear message: “Massachusetts is going to stay true to who we are.”

“We believe that bringing people of different backgrounds and perspectives to the table — in-

DEI, Page A7



Stirred, not shaken

Friday: A bit breezy, cool. High 43-48. Low 30-35.

Saturday: Sprinkles. High 49-54. Low 20-25.

High tide: 11:11 a.m., 11:39 p.m.

Sunrise: 6:21 Sunset: 5:33

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VOL. 307, NO. 59

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Suggested retail price \$4.00

